



THE DISTRICT



42
Schools



12,700+
Students



5th
Largest School
District in Iowa

THE RESEARCH OBJECTIVE

The Facilities Committee of the Board and the School Board asked Hanover Research to help determine whether Iowa City Community School District (ICCSd) should move forward with the development of a third comprehensive high school. They sought data-driven evidence of the pros and cons of large and small high schools, as well as macro-level information on high school distribution across the US.

Superintendent Stephen Murley explained why they requested Hanover to execute this initiative: "We knew we needed a broad base of research in a short period of time and that's not something we are equipped to do. Sometimes there is also a healthy dose of skepticism when it comes to large changes. The value added by having an external source was fairly significant."

Stephen Murley
Superintendent

"A significant value-add is recognizing that this research report is not written by support staff in my office; it is written for the community. It takes skill to take this information and reduce it down to two pages of key findings for some people and a comprehensive report for others. It is unique to engage the whole group and I do not know anyone else who could do that."

THE RESEARCH PROCESS

Hanover Research examined national, state, and regional data to provide empirical evidence about the benefits and disadvantages of small and large high schools. Specifically, analysts at Hanover:

- Examined the distribution of public high schools at the national, state, and regional levels;
- Grouped average high school enrollment by state and offered a focused analysis of the distribution of high schools by size in the State of Iowa;
- Profiled the number and size of high schools currently operated by peer districts in the greater Midwestern region; and
- Provided a comprehensive review of literature, highlighting empirical outcomes associated with high school size.

THE DISTRICT VALUE

When conducting its facilities master planning process to determine optimal class sizes, ICCSD hosted a three-day community engagement session. Hanover's report included a discussion of national high school enrollment data that served as a benchmark to enhance the community perspective during this session. These findings provided key district stakeholders with an understanding of class size and its implications on high school student success to guide informed decision-making.

Stephen affirmed how critical the research findings were: "We're going to be able to make a decision based on national trends rather than one without any context or perspective. We're able to have a more rational discussion about what we ought to be doing moving forward. The research helps frame the question that may be less emotion and more fact at the root of it."

For more information regarding this case study, contact info@hanoverresearch.com

PROJECT IMPACT IN THE MEDIA

The Gazette

Iowa City superintendent: New high school is still best option

Murley supports decision to build new high school
Gregg Hennigan

IOWA CITY – Iowa City school district Superintendent Stephen Murley on Tuesday reaffirmed his support for building a third comprehensive high school.

He said research on high school sizes supports the viability of a smaller school like the 900-student building the district is contemplating, and administrators are recommending the school board continue to move forward with its 2010 decision to eventually build a new high school.

The district has been on that path, but Murley's recommendation comes after some community members, and some school board members, have recently questioned the need for a new school.

The school board, meeting as its Facilities Committee Tuesday, was briefed on a high school size report conducted by Washington, D.C.-based Hanover Research. It says "small" high schools have fewer than 600 students, while "large" high schools have more than 1,500 students.

The district's existing comprehensive high schools, West High and City High, have 1,950 students and 1,450 students, respectively. Their capacities are 1,800 and 1,600, respectively. The district is exploring the idea of a high school, probably in the growing North Liberty area, of around 900 students.

Research has found no correlation between high school size and student achievement, according to the report. Large schools offer more courses, while small schools have more focused curricular offerings, the report found. Smaller schools typically have higher graduation and attendance rates.

A report by Iowa City school district administrators earlier this year found that a smaller high school would have similar course offering to City High and West High. Research shows both type of schools have positive social benefits, according to the report. Murley said the Hanover report "validates" the school board's previous decision to eventually build a new school.

Each school board member did not weigh in on his or her thinking, but no one expressed outright opposition to Murley's conclusions. Board member Jeff McGinness, who in March said he wanted administrators to explore alternatives to a new high school, said he supports a new school as long as it's part of a long-term facilities plan.

Any sort of timeline remains unclear, but Murley said he is actively looking for land for a high school, as well as parcels for an east-side elementary school. Part of the decision-making process involves getting more data. Murley wants to hire consultants to analyze enrollment projections, building capacities and attendance zones. Board members on Tuesday gave their consent for a request for proposals to be drawn up.

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<http://thegazette.com/2012/08/21/superintendent-recommends-new-high-school/elementary-school-district/>